Perspectives and Challenges of Internal Communication

What senior leaders expect

This session explores how senior managers understand the role of internal communication and what they expect it to contribute. The research discussed in the webinar highlights a function increasingly seen as strategic: helping people understand organizational direction, prepare for change, stay connected and contribute to shared objectives.

Several dimensions recur in leaders' accounts: transparency, cohesion, proximity between leaders and employees, two-way communication, attention to workforce diversity, digital channels and employee wellbeing. In uncertain environments, clear and transparent communication can help people understand what is changing and why. Listening matters too: employee voice can strengthen belonging and help people feel ownership of organizational work.

The session also considers pressures reshaping the function, including digital transformation and AI, sustainability and ESG expectations, cultural change, multigenerational workforces, talent attraction and retention, and mental health. These demands make internal communication more than the production and distribution of messages.

The practitioner perspective emphasizes that leaders are not simply buying communication outputs; they need sound judgment and advice. Communication can influence decisions before they are made, but practitioners need to work with the leaders and relationships available to them. Trust and confidence are central, and communication problems can sometimes reflect leadership or operational issues that communication alone cannot fix.

What this means for practice

- Connect communication plans to organizational decisions and outcomes, not just channel activity.
- Make space for employee questions and feedback, then show how that input is handled.
- Adapt messages and channels for different groups without losing transparency or consistency.
- Use curiosity and advice to build influence; recognize when the underlying issue is not a communication output problem.

The findings reflect the research presented in the webinar and should be read in that context, rather than assumed to represent every senior leader or organization.

Source: "ICRH-Europe webinar on 16 June 2026" transcript.